Northwind Collective — Remote Work & Travel Policy

Effective 2026. Policy owner: Priya Sharma, People Operations Lead (priya.sharma@northwind-tech.example, +91 98765 43210).

Remote Work Eligibility

Employees who have completed a 90-day probationary period may work remotely for up to three days per week, subject to manager approval and the operational needs of their specific team. Employees still within their 90-day probationary period are expected to work on-site full time unless a documented medical or legal accommodation applies.

Equipment and Home Office Setup

Equipment requests, including monitors, keyboards, and docking stations, are submitted through the IT helpdesk portal and typically ship within five business days. Remote employees are expected to be reachable during their team's core collaboration hours, defined as 10:00 to 15:00 in the employee's local time zone. Home office stipends of six hundred dollars annually are available to any employee who works remotely at least one day per week on a regular basis.

International Contractors

Contractors who are not based in the country where Northwind Collective maintains a registered entity may not work remotely without a written exception approved by Daniel Weber, Head of Global Compliance. This includes contractors based in Germany, who must obtain Daniel Weber's written exception before working remotely under this policy, regardless of the terms in their local contracting agreement.

Business Travel Approval Thresholds

Business travel under one thousand dollars requires only the employee's direct manager's approval. Business travel between one thousand and four thousand nine hundred ninety-nine dollars requires approval from the relevant Vice President. Business travel of five thousand dollars or more requires approval from both the Vice President of Finance and the Chief Financial Officer, and must be requested at least fourteen business days before departure.

Restricted Travel Destinations

Business travel to any location on the company's restricted-travel list requires pre-approval from both the employee's manager and the security team, regardless of trip duration or cost. Employees traveling internationally are automatically enrolled in a travel-tracking service that can locate and assist them in the event of a natural disaster, civil unrest, or medical emergency. All business travel must be booked through the approved travel portal so that the company can maintain accurate records of employee location for safety purposes.

Expenses While Traveling

Employees are reimbursed for reasonable incidental expenses while traveling, including a daily meal allowance that varies by destination city according to a published cost-of-living table. Mileage for personal vehicle use is reimbursed at the standard rate published annually by finance. Receipts are required for any single expense over twenty-five dollars, and expense reports must be submitted within thirty days of the original purchase date to be eligible for reimbursement.

Reporting Lines and Governance

This policy is owned and maintained by Priya Sharma, People Operations Lead. The Travel Coordinator role reports directly to Elena Petrova, Director of Global Operations, who is responsible for reviewing restricted-destination approvals on a

quarterly basis. Any proposed change to the approval thresholds in this policy must be reviewed by both Priya Sharma and Elena Petrova before taking effect.

Policy Violations

Employees who book travel or claim remote-work arrangements outside the terms of this policy without an approved exception may be required to reimburse the company for any resulting costs and may be subject to disciplinary action under the separate Code of Conduct policy. Repeated violations are escalated to the employee's Vice President and to Priya Sharma directly.

Emergency Contacts While Traveling

Any employee experiencing a travel emergency, including a missed connection that affects a business-critical meeting, a medical issue, or a security concern, should contact the twenty-four hour travel assistance line printed on the back of their company travel card before contacting their manager, so that professional assistance can be dispatched immediately. The travel assistance line is staffed by a third-party provider contracted directly by Elena Petrova's office and is independent of the employee's home country emergency services, which should still be contacted first in a life-threatening situation.

Annual Policy Review

This policy is reviewed annually every January by a committee chaired by Priya Sharma and including one representative from Finance and one representative from Legal. Proposed changes are circulated to all people managers for a two-week comment period before Elena Petrova signs off on the final version. The most recent review, completed in January 2026, raised the business-class travel threshold from eight hours to ten hours of continuous flight time and added the current international-contractor exception process involving Daniel Weber.

Data and Device Security While Traveling

Company laptops must remain encrypted and within the employee's physical possession or a locked hotel safe at all times while traveling; they must never be left unattended in a vehicle, including a locked one. Employees connecting to hotel or airport Wi-Fi must use the company-issued VPN client for any access to internal systems. Any lost or stolen device must be reported to IT Security within one hour of discovery, in addition to any required police report, so that remote wipe procedures can begin immediately.

Visa and Immigration Support

Employees traveling internationally for business are responsible for confirming their own visa requirements well in advance of departure, but the Travel Coordinator can provide a letter of invitation or employment verification letter on request, typically within three business days. Employees who hold a visa sponsored by Northwind Collective for their own immigration status must notify Priya Sharma's team before any international travel, since certain visa categories restrict travel outside the country of residence without separate authorization.

Team Offsites and Group Travel

Team offsites involving five or more employees traveling together follow a separate group-booking process managed through the approved travel portal rather than individual bookings, regardless of the total cost, because group bookings require sign-off from both the organizing manager and Elena Petrova's office for safety-tracking purposes. Group offsite budgets are approved as a single line item rather than requiring each attendee's travel to clear the individual approval thresholds described above.

Per Diem and Local Transportation

Local transportation while traveling, including rideshare and public transit, is reimbursed in full with a receipt and does not count toward the daily meal allowance described above. Employees are encouraged to use public transit where it is reasonably available and safe, both to control cost and to reduce the trip's environmental footprint, but a rideshare or taxi is always acceptable for late-night travel or when carrying company equipment. Rental cars require a separate pre-approval from the employee's manager regardless of the overall trip's approval tier, since insurance terms vary significantly by destination country.

Combining Business Travel With Personal Time

Employees may extend a business trip with personal vacation days, commonly called a "bleisure" trip, provided the personal portion is clearly marked in the travel booking and does not increase the airfare or lodging cost charged to the company. Any cost increase attributable to the personal extension, including a later return flight, must be paid by the employee directly at the time of booking rather than reimbursed and later deducted. Approval for the business portion of a bleisure trip still follows the ordinary thresholds in this policy.

Questions About This Policy

Questions about this policy can be directed to the People team at hr@northwindcollective.example, or through the HR portal's help desk ticketing system. Priya Sharma holds an open office hour every Thursday afternoon for employees who prefer to raise a question in person rather than submit a ticket.